

A Strategist's Basic Bookshelf

An Annotated Reading List



RICHARD RUMELT

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To learn strategy, you should read some basic source books. This list presented here mixes military, political, and business strategy sources. Some are easy and inviting, while others demand more concentrated attention to unfamiliar background events or archaic narrative styles.

I include only a few books on business strategy. When reading about business strategy, you should avoid works that claim to provide “winning” strategies and other simple formulas for success and profit. The idea that we can all be like the winners if we only follow their example is the oldest scam in popular culture. Also, avoid modern

books on “leadership”—these are almost all about perfecting oneself to project a compelling vision. They are not about actually leading anyone.

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Classic Military and Political Strategy

Sun Tzu, *The Art of War* (5th century BC). Considered one of the most impactful strategy books ever written, this early Chinese work is believed to have been authored by General Sun Tzu during the Eastern Zhou dynasty. It contains 13 chapters that present insights on leadership, deception, terrain, and the art of achieving victory without direct confrontation. *The Art of War* shaped the course of East Asian military practices for centuries and has influenced Western military thought and other fields. Its teachings (e.g., “subdue the enemy without fighting”) are still part of the curriculum in military academies and business schools, with many modern executives applying Sun Tzu’s principles as frameworks for competitive strategy and negotiation.

Thucydides, *History of the Peloponnesian War* (5th century BC). Thucydides was an exiled Athenian general. His eyewitness account details the conflict between Athens and Sparta (431–404 BC). It illustrates power dynamics, coalition politics, and the interplay between war and humanity. If nothing else, read Pericles’ funeral oration (Ch. VI) and the description of the aftermath of the debacle in Sicily (Ch. XXIV). Thucydides provides a cautionary tale about employing war as a policy tool, with insights into the pitfalls of excess and the “Thucydides Trap” involving rising and ruling powers. His theory of motives—“fear, honor,

interest”—and the renowned *Melian Dialogue* remain influential in strategy and international relations education.

Kautilya (also known as Chanakya), *The Arthashastra* (circa 3rd century BC). Often referred to as “the Indian Machiavelli,” Kautilya was a prominent mentor who guided Chandragupta Maurya in establishing an empire. The *Arthashastra* covers statecraft, foreign relations, economics, and warfare. It promotes a pragmatic and often ruthless approach to governance, encompassing tactics such as espionage, diplomacy, and military strategies. After being lost for centuries, it was rediscovered in 1905 and contains many concepts that resonate in Machiavelli’s *The Prince*.

Niccolò Machiavelli, *The Prince* (1513). Written as a concise guide for rulers on gaining and maintaining power, it was developed by a Florentine diplomat during Italy’s volatile city-state politics. The reader is struck by his brutal honesty. Paying homage to skill, he also recognizes that it only achieves when the situation is ripe. Thus, in explaining how Cyrus conquered Persia, he says, “It was necessary that Cyrus should find the Persians discontented with the government of the Medes, and the Medes soft and effeminate through their long peace.” Recognized as a foundational text in modern political strategy and realist philosophy, the term “Machiavellian” has become a descriptor for pragmatic statecraft. Few works in political philosophy are as significant to grand strategy and diplomacy.

Miyamoto Musashi, *The Book of Five Rings* (1645). A reflective piece written by the legendary samurai in his later years, focusing on sword fighting and strategy. While it is mainly centered on individual combat, the five chapters—“Earth,” “Water,” “Fire,” “Wind,” and “Void”—encapsulate principles that apply to warfare and competition in general. Musashi promotes the idea of adaptability and an “indirect” method to unsettle adversaries. Over time, *Five Rings* has become a strategy classic, studied by individuals in business, sports, and various

competitive domains. Musashi's belief that the warrior's path aligns with the strategist's has echoed well beyond 17th-century Japan.

Carl von Clausewitz, *On War* (1832). A comprehensive analysis of warfare from the perspective of a Prussian general involved in the Napoleonic Wars. Posthumously published by his wife, *On War* explores ambiguity and uncertainty and emphasizes the importance of political objectives. Clausewitz stated that “war is a mere continuation of policy by other means,” encapsulating his argument that military strategy serves political purposes. *On War* remains an influential work on military strategy that is relevant and thought-provoking for contemporary strategic discourse. Pay particular attention to his chapter on *surprise*: “It lies more or less at the foundation of all undertakings, for without it the preponderance at the decisive point is not properly conceivable.”

Antoine-Henri Jomini, *Summary of the Art of War* (1838). As a contemporary of Clausewitz, Baron de Jomini was a Swiss military officer who served Napoleon. His *Art of War* outlines Napoleonic battlefield strategies through prescriptive formulas (such as lines of operation and points of decision) and promotes the idea of warfare as a systematic science. Jomini's contributions significantly influenced military practices in the 19th century. Few authors impacted military operations before 1870 as profoundly as Jomini, whose theories were instrumental for many generals during the U.S. Civil War. He supported the idea of concentrated force targeting enemy weaknesses and using interior lines—principles that became foundational in military academies. However, after 1870, Clausewitz's theories eclipsed Jomini's work, and his writings are less commonly studied today. Nonetheless, reading Jomini provides insight into strategy teaching in the 1800s and contrasts with Clausewitz's perspectives.

Alfred Thayer Mahan, *The Influence of Sea Power upon History, 1660–1783* (1890). This seminal work by U.S. Navy Captain A.T. Mahan outlines how maritime dominance shaped the destinies of major powers, particularly Britain's rise. Mahan argues that a state's strength and

prosperity hinge on its naval and commercial capabilities. This book had a profound impact, regarded by scholars as the most significant single volume on maritime strategy, embraced by all major navies. It triggered the naval arms race leading to World War I. The Mahanian principles—developing battleship fleets, capturing coaling stations, and controlling critical chokepoints—shaped naval strategies for the British Empire, Imperial Germany, the United States, and Japan. Additionally, the concept of Sea Power contributed to the evolution of U.S. strategic thinking as America emerged as a great power, especially the relationship between economic power and global military policy. Mahan's analysis of England's landed aristocracy is fascinating: "Such a class, whatever its defects otherwise, readily takes up and carries on a sound political tradition, is naturally proud of its country's glory, and comparatively insensible to the sufferings of the community by which that glory is maintained. It readily lays on the pecuniary burden necessary for preparation and for endurance of war. Being as a body rich, it feels those burdens less. Not being commercial, the sources of its own wealth are not so immediately endangered, and it does not share that political timidity which characterizes those whose property is exposed and business threatened—the proverbial timidity of capital."

B.H. Liddell Hart, *Strategy: The Indirect Approach* (1954). Liddell Hart advocates for the "indirect approach," which focuses on targeting the enemy's vulnerabilities and disrupting their balance rather than engaging in direct confrontation. Criticizing the costly frontal assaults of World War I, he played a significant role in shaping armored warfare in the interwar period. This work is regarded as a foundational text in military theory, often mentioned alongside the works of Sun Tzu and Clausewitz. Liddell Hart emphasizes the importance of flexibility, surprise, and the psychological impact on opponents. While some of his assertions, such as the indirect influence on the German Blitzkrieg, may be debated, his succinct prose and broad range of examples solidify this book's status as a significant contribution to modern strategy.

Thomas C. Schelling, *The Strategy of Conflict* (1960). This work integrates game-theoretic analysis with military and political strategy. Schelling, an American economist and planner during the Cold War, utilizes game theory to explore themes of conflict and cooperation through various examples, including nuclear deterrence, bargaining, and limited war. He discusses ideas such as credible commitments, deterrence based on the threat of mutually assured destruction, focal points, and the rationality of irrational behaviors. Emerging from the Cold War arms race backdrop, the book offers fresh insights into war prevention. *The Strategy of Conflict* transformed the field of strategic studies, earning him a Nobel Prize in economics for his analyses of conflict and cooperation. Its clear explanations (such as the “Chicken” game and negotiation standoffs) remain relevant in diplomatic and business strategies.

Sir Lawrence Freedman, *Strategy: A History* (2013). Lawrence Freedman is Emeritus Professor of War Studies at King’s College London. This book explores the evolution of strategic thought from ancient times up to the 21st century. Freedman examines strategy across various fields, including warfare, politics, social movements, and business, illustrating how this concept has “pervaded every sphere of life.” He begins with survival strategies among primates and progresses through the ideas of influential thinkers such as Sun Tzu, Machiavelli, Clausewitz, and Marx, along with contemporary corporate intellectuals like Peter Drucker. Freedman wonders whether we can genuinely influence history or are merely subject to chance and circumstance. Although academic, the book remains engaging. It serves as both an intellectual history and a critical exploration of the attainability of strategic goals, making it a good follow-up for those familiar with the primary classical texts.

John Lewis Gaddis, *On Grand Strategy* (2018). This book reflects on statecraft and how to reconcile lofty ambitions with realistic capabilities. The Yale historian, known for his Cold War expertise, draws

on his extensive experience co-teaching a well-regarded “Grand Strategy” seminar. He intertwines stories of notable leaders and thinkers—from Herodotus, Thucydides, and Augustus to Queen Elizabeth I, Napoleon, and Lincoln, among others. The narrative uses Isaiah Berlin’s fable of the fox and the hedgehog (representing multiple small ideas versus one dominant idea) to illustrate strategic thinking. The book is engaging and rich with stories. For professionals in defense and security, *On Grand Strategy* serves as an introductory guide on conceptualizing and implementing strategy. Gaddis highlights the importance of balancing resources with goals, maintaining adaptability, and learning from historical victories and failures.

Henry Kissinger, *Leadership: Six Studies in World Strategy* (Political, 2022). “Leaders,” writes Henry Kissinger, “think and act at the intersection of two axes: the first, between the past and the future; the second, between the abiding values and aspirations of those they lead. They must balance what they know, which is necessarily drawn from the past, with what they intuit about the future, which is inherently conjectural and uncertain. This intuitive grasp of direction enables leaders to set objectives and lay down a strategy.” In *Leadership*, Kissinger examines the lives of six prominent leaders: Konrad Adenauer, Charles de Gaulle, Richard Nixon, Anwar Sadat, Lee Kuan Yew, and Margaret Thatcher. He explores the strategies each exemplified. Combining historical insight, public experience, and personal knowledge, Kissinger provides a unique perspective since he engaged in many of the events he recounts. The book benefits from insights and judgments that only Kissinger could offer, concluding with his thoughts on global order and the crucial role of leadership in today’s world.

Eliot A. Cohen and John Gooch, *Military Misfortunes: The Anatomy of Failure in War* (Military, 1990). What causes competent armies to fail? Cohen and Gooch provide insights into this question in their analysis of failed military operations. It offers fascinating battlefield stories and innovative explanations for the factors that weaken armies. This book

has established itself as the definitive examination of the unforeseen disasters that strike presumably capable militaries. The chapter on the early failure of the U.S. in dealing with the German submarine war in 1940 is a must-read. The 2006 edition features a new Afterword reflecting on America's errors in Iraq, Somalia, and the War on Terror.

Business and Corporate Strategy (20th–21st Century)

Alfred Sloan, *My Years with General Motors* (1963). This is one of the few business books that can be called a classic. Bill Gates called it out as the best book to read on business. Business Week listed it as number one on its “indispensable” reading bookshelf. The core lessons of the book are in how Sloan created the product policy (strategy) that took GM to the top of the heap in the automobile industry, and his analysis of the distinct roles of corporate management and those of the operating divisions.

Michael E. Porter. *Competitive Strategy* (1980). Now in its 60th printing, *Competitive Strategy* continues to be a vital resource in business education. Porter’s “Five Forces” model flipped industrial organization economics to a businessperson’s point of view. Thus, corporate profit flowed from positioning in and within an industry characterized by rivalry, buyer power, supplier power, ease of entry, and availability of substitutes. A must-read for anyone working in business strategy. His follow-on book, *Competitive Advantage*, is more nuanced and also a must-read.

Clayton M. Christensen, *The Innovator’s Dilemma* (1997). This book delves into how successful companies can crumble under the pressure of “disruptive innovation.” Christensen explains that market leaders, focused on current customer needs, often overlook emerging technologies that initially underperform, enabling new entrants to seize market leadership. This paradox—the “innovator’s dilemma”—awakened

a generation of business leaders to the fear of disruption, becoming one of the most impactful business texts ever published.

Chan Kim and Renée Mauborgne, *Blue Ocean Strategy* (2005). A best-selling book aimed at helping companies find “blue oceans”—new, unexplored markets—rather than battling competitors in the saturated “red oceans” of existing industries. The book is essential reading because of its widespread influence—over 4 million copies sold and translations in 47 languages. Its central idea advocates for making competition irrelevant by achieving significant leaps in value, as companies like Cirque du Soleil and Southwest Airlines exemplify. Although some critics argue that “blue oceans” eventually turn red when others replicate the approach, the principles within the book have firmly established themselves in the business world.

Richard Rumelt, *Good Strategy/Bad Strategy: The Difference and Why it Matters* (2011). This book offers a realistic view of what constitutes an effective strategy. A UCLA professor and experienced consultant, Rumelt was frustrated by the buzzwords and vague vision statements frequently presented as “strategy.” He delineates the core components of a solid strategy: a clear assessment of the issue, a guiding policy, and coherent actions. In contrast, he critiques “poor strategy” as mere fluff, idealistic objectives, or a disjointed list of unconnected initiatives. Upon its release, the book “immediately struck a chord” and has since become a highly regarded text on business strategy.

Biographies — Military and Political

Robin Lane Fox, *Alexander the Great*. Robin Lane Fox’s very readable biography examines Alexander’s extraordinary campaigns, emphasizing how strategic audacity, deliberate risk-taking, and inventive logistical strategies empowered a small Macedonian army to seize tremendous Persian lands.

Adrian Goldsworthy, *Caesar: Life of a Colossus*. Read this to learn about Caesar and about Roman history. He is quite good on Caesar's military campaigns and Roman generalship. He also highlights how Caesar's talent for coalition-building, navigating Roman political systems, and bold military tactics allowed him to conquer Rome and transform Western civilization.

Jack Weatherford, *Genghis Khan and the Making of the Modern World*. Weatherford revamps the traditional image of Genghis Khan by highlighting the strategic advancements brought by the Mongols, such as meritocracy, information systems, psychological tactics, and swift movements. These approaches enabled an extraordinary conquest and effective governance of the largest contiguous land empire, transforming global trade, diplomacy, and administration.

Andrew Roberts, *Napoleon: A Life*. Roberts provides an in-depth review of Napoleon Bonaparte's military and political strategies, uncovering the techniques that shaped his groundbreaking warfare tactics, operational flexibility, logistical control, and capacity to dominate battlefields. The biography highlights the idea of "strategic tempo," illustrating how swift decision-making and continuous offensive initiatives revolutionized European warfare.

Ron Chernow, *Grant*. Chernow's work showcases Ulysses S. Grant's strategic genius in maneuver warfare, emphasizing his steadfast and unwavering pursuit of objectives despite challenges. The biography provides insights into Grant's quiet proficiency in operational flexibility, accurate evaluations of enemy weaknesses, and an unyielding drive for victory.

Jean Edward Smith, *Eisenhower in War and Peace*. This examination of Eisenhower delves into the intricacies of coalition warfare, highlighting Eisenhower's adept coordination of multinational operations, his management of rival personalities, and his logistics-driven, timely, and consensus-oriented strategy. The biography underscores Eisenhower's

ability to balance diplomatic priorities with military aims, which laid the groundwork for contemporary coalition strategies.

Andrew Roberts, *Churchill: Walking with Destiny*. Roberts vividly illustrates Winston Churchill's strategic insight and leadership, showcasing his talent for motivating national resilience and resolve. The book emphasizes Churchill's foresight regarding strategic threats, effective communication techniques, psychological grasp of leadership, and key decisions that influenced British and global strategies during WWII.

Doris Kearns Goodwin, *Team of Rivals: The Political Genius of Abraham Lincoln*. Goodwin's biography explores Lincoln's remarkable political skill, demonstrating how his choice to include political adversaries in his cabinet fostered greater unity during the Civil War. The book highlights Lincoln's psychological insight, political timing, adept rivalry management, and the patient quest for strategic consensus, turning political challenges into strategic advantages.

Ezra F. Vogel, *Deng Xiaoping and the Transformation of China*. Vogel provides in-depth analysis of Deng Xiaoping's pragmatic strategy, emphasizing his patience and methodical approach to implementing economic reforms that turned China into a global economic powerhouse. Deng's careful incrementalism, strategic ambiguity—described as "crossing the river by feeling the stones"—and his ability to balance ideological rigidity with practical flexibility exemplify strategic adaptability.

Anthony Sampson, *Mandela: The Authorized Biography*. Sampson's comprehensive biography showcases Nelson Mandela's remarkable strategic patience, moral leadership, and knack for fostering consensus while navigating intricate political changes. Mandela's clear strategy for pursuing national reconciliation—utilizing symbolic gestures and a long-term vision to oversee significant societal transformation—makes this

work essential for understanding strategic leadership in political environments.

Robert Coram, *Boyd: The Fighter Pilot Who Changed the Art of War*.

Coram's insightful biography of John Boyd unveils the development and influence of Boyd's groundbreaking OODA (Observe-Orient-Decide-Act) loop framework, which has reshaped contemporary military and business strategies. Boyd's emphasis on agility, adaptability, and swift decision-making cycles demonstrates how strategic innovation stems from intellectual discipline and practical experimentation.

William Manchester, *American Caesar: Douglas MacArthur 1880–1964*.

Manchester's biography explores Douglas MacArthur's strategic bravado, engaging leadership, and the careful equilibrium between military aspirations and geopolitical circumstances. It offers valuable perspectives on MacArthur's operational boldness, the complexities and advantages of charismatic leadership, and the strategic difficulties tied to civil-military relations during crucial historical events.

Biographies—Business

Ron Chernow, *Titan: The Life of John D. Rockefeller, Sr.* Chernow's comprehensive biography reveals Rockefeller's groundbreaking strategic vision behind Standard Oil, the first major industrial monopoly. Through detailed documentation, Chernow showcases Rockefeller's vertical and horizontal integration innovation, his amazing operational efficiency, disciplined cost management, and clever application of economies of scale. The book illustrates how Rockefeller methodically eliminated competitors and utilized strategic partnerships and regulatory insights, offering a key example of corporate strategic thinking.

David Nasaw, *Andrew Carnegie*. Nasaw paints a detailed picture of Carnegie's strategic brilliance in steel production, illustrating how he transformed manufacturing via vertical integration, from sourcing raw

materials to transporting and distributing finished goods. Carnegie's strong focus on cost management, commitment to technological advancements, and strategic investments in efficiency developed lasting competitive advantages, establishing core strategic concepts regarding efficiency, scale, and market supremacy.

Walter Isaacson, *Steve Jobs*. Isaacson offers unique insights into Jobs' intricate personality and strategic mindset. The biography highlights Jobs' talent for predicting consumer needs, intense focus on user experience, relentless drive for product simplification, and unwavering demand for seamless hardware and software integration. Isaacson illustrates Jobs' view of innovation as a strategy.

Brad Stone, *The Everything Store: Jeff Bezos and the Age of Amazon*. This biography explores Bezos' strategic long-term vision, emphasizing his core principle of customer obsession, dedication to operational excellence, and unwavering reinvestment in Amazon's essential infrastructure and logistics. Bezos' strategic choices—including platform diversification, competitive pricing, swift iteration, and significant investments like AWS—demonstrate the effectiveness of persistent long-term strategic execution and illustrate how customer-focused innovation leads to ongoing market disruption.

Sam Walton and John Huey, *Sam Walton: Made In America*. Walton's straightforward autobiography unveils his key strategic insights, focusing on disciplined cost control, decentralized decision-making, innovation in supply chains, and constant experimentation with store formats. His unwavering drive for everyday low prices, logistical efficiency, and flexible inventory management transformed retail strategy, illustrating how operational creativity, frugality, and the ability to scale strategically support lasting competitive advantage.

Jack Welch and John A. Byrne, *Jack: Straight from the Gut*. Welch compellingly depicts his overhaul of General Electric by emphasizing strategic clarity and strict competitive benchmarks. His approaches—

such as the "number one or number two" principle, proactive divestment of underachieving segments, and fostering leader empowerment—demonstrate how strategic discipline, effective talent management, cultural alignment, and stringent performance metrics were supposed to result in a nimble, competitive organization. One has to look at what happened after Welch to make a fully informed judgment on his approach.

Lee Iacocca and William Novak, *Iacocca: An Autobiography*. Iacocca's compelling account of Chrysler's brink of failure and rejuvenation presents a strategic framework for crisis leadership, turnaround management, and innovative marketing strategies. He emphasizes the urgent need for clear strategy, decisive action, inventive product approaches, and effective stakeholder engagement, showing how strategic bravery can turn around fortunes in times of severe challenge.

Ashlee Vance, *Elon Musk: Tesla, SpaceX, and the Quest for a Fantastic Future*. Vance's biography offers crucial insights into Musk's strategic vision, analyzing how Musk persistently utilizes vertical integration, rapid innovation, and the development of disruptive technologies. His strategic reasoning—encompassing risk-taking with ambitious deadlines, direct engagement with consumers, and constant technological advancements—showcases the effectiveness of daring, integrated strategies in transforming entire industries.

Louis V. Gerstner Jr., *Who Says Elephants Can't Dance?* Gerstner's compelling description of IBM's remarkable turnaround offers essential insights into corporate reinvention, clear strategy, and adaptive leadership. His method involved shifting IBM's focus from hardware supremacy to comprehensive services, restructuring the corporate culture, and synchronizing strategic execution via decisive organizational changes. His narrative highlights the importance of realistic strategy, swift execution, and integrated cultural and strategic changes during crises.

Bryce G. Hoffman, *American Icon: Alan Mulally and the Fight to Save Ford Motor Company*. A detailed examination of Mulally's disciplined and structured approach to transforming Ford during a time of crisis. Mulally emphasized strategic simplicity through the "One Ford" plan, maintained ruthless transparency, concentrated intensely on execution, and fostered cultural accountability. This illustrates the effectiveness of coherent, well-communicated strategies paired with disciplined operational execution. Mulally's strategic methodology shows how clarity, alignment, and consistency can steer a company through significant disruption and challenges.

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